TLP:CLEAR Unrestricted public release.

CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE REPORT

OpenSSH emergency fix for musl-based Linux where long passwords bypass login to password-disabled accounts

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CTI-20261106-02	1.0 · 2026-11-06 08:03 EST	TLP:CLEAR	Vulnerability
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2026-11-05	No update	None	Nick Sturgeon

VULNERABILITY | HIGH | PATCH AVAILABLE; NO EXPLOITATION REPORTED | OVERALL CONFIDENCE: HIGH

BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT

On 2026-11-05 the OpenSSH project shipped Portable OpenSSH 10.6p2 with what it calls a critical security workaround for a password authentication bypass in sshd. The bug hits Linux systems that use the musl C library and run sshd without PAM [S3] [S4]. The researcher who found it, Ozgun Kultekin of Wakefield, calls it "sshole" [S5]. An attacker who can reach the SSH port and knows an account name can send a password of 257 to 1,024 bytes. That logs them into any account whose password field is a bare "*", which is the usual marker for a key-only or password-disabled account [S1] [S2] [S5] [S6]. Alpine Linux says the attack works on every try and needs one connection [S6].

The cause is a chain of old design choices. For 5 and 6 (SHA-256/SHA-512 crypt) hashes, musl's crypt() rejects passwords over 256 bytes and returns the string "*" when it fails. Since a 2016 change made for the CVE-2016-6210 timing fix, sshd hashes attempts against "*" accounts using a salt borrowed from another account's real hash. sshd then compares the returned "*" with the stored "*", finds a match and accepts the login [S2] [S5] [S6]. The 10.6p2 workaround makes sshd refuse a match when the stored field is shorter than four characters. OpenSSH says the root cause lies outside sshd [S2] [S3] [S4].

A system is exposed only when all of these hold: musl libc, sshd without PAM (the default Alpine openssh-server package, or openssh-server-

pam with UsePAM no), PasswordAuthentication yes (the default), at least one account with a "*" password field, and at least one other local account with a real 5 or 6 hash [S6]. Glibc distributions (Debian, Ubuntu, Fedora and others) are not affected. Neither are PAM-based sshd, Dropbear and non-Linux systems [S1] [S2] [S5]. The accounts at highest risk are root (shipped as root:* since about Alpine 3.16), key-only users, and directory-service users served through musl-nscd. Also at risk is the "alpine" user in official tiny-cloud images (qcow2, VHD, AMI) from 3.18.11 through 3.24.3, which has passwordless doas and so leads to root once any 6 hash exists on the host [S2] [S6]. Other musl platforms to check are OpenWrt (only if OpenSSH replaced the default Dropbear), Buildroot, Yocto, and container images that run sshd [S1] [S2] [S5].

No CVE had been assigned as of 2026-11-06, so there is no CVSS, EPSS or KEV entry. No exploitation in the wild has been reported [S1] [S2] [S6]. The researcher has published technical details and a public checker repository, and the trigger is just a long password, so the barrier to exploitation is very low [S5]. What to do: update openssh (Alpine: apk upgrade -U -a, then rc-service sshd restart, because upgrading does not restart the running daemon). Fixed Alpine packages are published for branches 3.16 through edge, and the 3.21.10, 3.22.8, 3.23.8 and 3.24.4 point releases include the fix [S6] [S7]. If you cannot update, set PasswordAuthentication no everywhere it appears in the configuration, including Match blocks. Then look in /var/log/messages for "Accepted password for" lines naming accounts that have no password. If such a login cannot be ruled out, treat the host as compromised [S6].

Key judgments

LIKELY · MODERATE CONFIDENCE
Opportunistic scanning and exploitation attempts against internet-exposed Alpine and other musl-based SSH servers will likely appear within the next few weeks. The trigger is trivial: one connection with a long password against a known account name such as root or alpine. Full technical details and a public checker are already available. [S2] [S5] [S6]

VERY LIKELY · HIGH CONFIDENCE
Unpatched Alpine cloud instances built from tiny-cloud images 3.18.11 through 3.24.3 that have gained any 6 password hash will very likely give an attacker root, through the default alpine account and its passwordless doas. [S2] [S6]

LIKELY · MODERATE CONFIDENCE
Embedded and appliance products built on musl with OpenSSH (Buildroot, Yocto, some OpenWrt builds) will likely stay vulnerable for months, because vendors are slow to ship firmware and asset owners often do not know which libc their devices use. [S1] [S5]

LIKELY · LOW CONFIDENCE
A CVE identifier will likely be assigned in the coming weeks, after which vulnerability scanners will start flagging affected packages. Until then, scanner coverage will probably be incomplete. [S2] [S6] [S8]

INDICATORS OF COMPROMISE

No attacker infrastructure, malware or hashes have been reported, and no exploitation has been observed. The entries below are host and log artifacts for exposure checks and hunting, taken from the Alpine advisory, the researcher's write-up and press coverage dated 2026-11-05. A few are marked derived.

Type	Indicator (defanged)	Context	Provenance	First seen	Source
other	`SSH password authentication attempt with a password 257-1024 bytes long`	The exploit trigger. musl crypt() fails on 5/6 hashing for passwords over 256 bytes and returns "*", which matches a "*" password field. sshd does not log the password, so the length cannot be seen in standard logs. Network or honeypot sensors that see SSH authentication packets of unusual size may catch it.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S2] [S5] [S6]
other	`Password of 300 'A' characters`	Test password the researcher used to show the bypass, which granted a uid 0 session. A password of 256 'A' characters did not trigger it. Possible pattern for scanners or copycat attempts.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S5]
other	`sshd: Accepted password for <account with "*" password field>`	Main log indicator. A successful password login for an account that has no password, such as alpine, root or a key-only user, points to exploitation. On Alpine it is logged to /var/log/messages.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S1] [S2] [S6]
command	`grep "Accepted password" /var/log/messages`	Hunting command BleepingComputer gave for finding successful password logins on Alpine hosts.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S1]
command	`grep '^alpine:' /etc/shadow`	Confirms whether the suspect account's shadow field is "*". Match this against any Accepted password line for the same account.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S1]
command	`sshd -T | grep -i passwordauthentication`	Exposure check from the Alpine advisory. After mitigation it should return 'passwordauthentication no'.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S2] [S6]
other	`alpine:*`	Shadow entry for the default alpine user in official tiny-cloud images (3.18.11 through 3.24.3), which has passwordless doas. Exposed once any 6 hash exists on the host.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S2] [S6]

Type	Indicator (defanged)	Context	Provenance	First seen	Source
other	`root:*`	Shadow entry for root in Alpine base images since about 3.16. Direct root login is blocked by the default PermitRootLogin prohibit-password, but is exposed if PermitRootLogin yes is set.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S5] [S6]
filepath	`/var/log/messages`	Default Alpine syslog destination where sshd authentication lines are written. Review it for Accepted password entries.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S1] [S6]
filepath	`/etc/shadow`	Holds the password fields. An exposed host has at least one "*" field plus at least one 5 or 6 hash.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S1] [S6]
filepath	`~/.ssh/authorized_keys`	The advisory says to review authorized_keys changes after a suspect login. An attacker who gets a shell would likely add a key here to keep access after the patch. Path is the standard OpenSSH default per user, including /root/.ssh/authorized_keys.	DERIVED		[S2] [S6]
filepath	`/etc/doas.conf`	The advisory says to review doas usage. doas configuration (the standard OpenDoas path on Alpine; some versions use /etc/doas.d/) decides whether a hijacked account such as alpine can escalate to root without a password.	DERIVED		[S6]
port	`22/tcp`	Default SSH port the attack is delivered over. Hosts may run sshd on other ports.	DERIVED		[S2] [S6]
url	`hxxps[://]github[.]com/oz9un/sshole`	The researcher's public checker repository linked from sshhole.com. Not malicious infrastructure. Listed because it lowers the barrier to testing and copycat exploitation. Not opened for this report.	REPORTED	2026-11-05	[S5]

Indicators are defanged (hxxp, [.], [@]) so they cannot be clicked. "Reported" means stated in a source; "Derived" means inferred by the analyst from the source material and should be validated before blocking.

TACTICS, TECHNIQUES & PROCEDURES (TTPS)

An attacker reaches sshd on a musl-based host that has PAM disabled and password authentication enabled. They pick a username likely to have a "*" password field, such as root, alpine, a key-only service user or a directory user, and submit a password between 257 and 1,024 bytes. Because the "*"

field holds no salt, sshd borrows the salt from another local account's 5/6 hash. musl's crypt() rejects the oversized input and returns "*", which equals the stored field, so sshd grants a session. That takes one connection and works every time. From the alpine account in tiny-cloud images, passwordless doas gives immediate root. After that, the advisory expects persistence through new users, modified files or authorized_keys entries [S2] [S5] [S6].

MITRE ATT&CK mapping

Tactic	Technique	Procedure observed	Detection opportunity
Reconnaissance	T1595.002 Active Scanning: Vulnerability Scanning	Likely scanning for SSH servers whose banners and behavior point to Alpine or musl builds. The researcher's checker is public. Inferred; no scanning has been reported. [S5]	Watch for spikes in SSH connections from new sources to Alpine or appliance hosts. Track banner-grab activity at perimeter sensors.
Initial Access	T1133 External Remote Services	Logs in through an internet- or network-exposed sshd that has password authentication enabled, without any valid credential. [S1] [S2] [S6]	Alert on sshd 'Accepted password for' lines where the account has a "*" shadow field or is expected to be key-only.
Defense Evasion	T1078.003 Valid Accounts: Local Accounts	Gets a session as an existing local account (root, alpine, key-only users) whose password login is meant to be disabled, so the login looks like a normal one. [S2] [S6]	Baseline which accounts may use password authentication. Flag password logins for any other account.
Initial Access	T1078.002 Valid Accounts: Domain Accounts	Directory-service users (nslcd, winbind, sssd through musl-nscd) have no shadow entry and are also exposed. This could give access under a domain identity. [S6]	Look for SSH password logins by directory users on Alpine hosts, matched against directory audit logs.
Privilege Escalation	T1548.003 Abuse Elevation Control Mechanism: Sudo and Sudo Caching	Uses passwordless doas (Alpine's sudo equivalent) on the alpine account in tiny-cloud images to get root. [S1] [S2] [S6]	Review doas usage logs and process trees where an SSH session spawns doas soon after a password login.
Persistence	T1098.004 Account Manipulation: SSH Authorized Keys	The advisory says to check authorized_keys for changes after a suspect login. Adding a key keeps access after the patch. [S2] [S6]	File integrity monitoring on authorized_keys files, and comparison against the configuration management baseline.
Persistence	T1136.001 Create Account: Local Account	The advisory says to review recently created users on exposed machines. [S2] [S6]	Diff /etc/passwd and /etc/shadow against a baseline. Watch for adduser and useradd execution.

Detection & hunting

Queries are built from the reported behavior and indicators. They are untested; tune field names for your environment.

Successful SSH password login to a normally password-less account (Sigma) `SIGMA`

```
title: SSH Password Login To Key-Only Or Locked Account (musl sshole)
status: experimental
logsource:
  product: linux
  service: sshd
detection:
  selection:
    message|contains: 'Accepted password for'
  accounts:
    message|contains:
      - 'Accepted password for root '
      - 'Accepted password for alpine '
  condition: selection and accounts
fields:
  - host
  - message
falsepositives:
  - Hosts where root or alpine have a legitimately set password
level: high
```

Add known key-only service accounts to the accounts list. Applies to Alpine syslog (/var/log/messages) once forwarded to a SIEM.

Password logins on hosts whose account should be key-only (Splunk SPL) `SPLUNK SPL`

```
index=linux (sourcetype=syslog OR sourcetype=linux_secure) process=sshd "Accepted password for"
| rex "Accepted password for (?<user>\S+) from (?<src_ip>\S+) port"
| lookup keyonly_accounts host user OUTPUT expected_auth
| where expected_auth="key" OR user IN ("root","alpine")
| stats earliest(_time) as first latest(_time) as last count by host user src_ip
```

keyonly_accounts is a lookup you build from shadow inventory (accounts whose field is "*"). Review every hit from untrusted sources.

SSH password login followed by doas on Alpine (KQL, Syslog table) `KQL`

```
let logins = Syslog
| where ProcessName == "sshd" and SyslogMessage has "Accepted password for"
| extend User = extract(@"Accepted password for (\S+) from", 1, SyslogMessage), SrcIp = extract(@"from (\S+) port", 1, SyslogMessage)
| project LoginTime = TimeGenerated, Computer, User, SrcIp;
let doas = Syslog
| where ProcessName == "doas"
| project DoasTime = TimeGenerated, Computer, DoasMsg = SyslogMessage;
logins
| join kind=inner doas on Computer
| where DoasTime between (LoginTime .. LoginTime + 30m)
| project LoginTime, Computer, User, SrcIp, DoasTime, DoasMsg
```

Assumes Alpine syslog is forwarded to Microsoft Sentinel. doas logging depends on configuration. Run the login query by itself for a wider view.

Exposure sweep across managed Linux fleet (shell via RMM) `SPLUNK SPL`

```
index=inventory sourcetype=linux_os_release ID=alpine
| join host [ search index=inventory sourcetype=sshd_effective_config passwordauthentication=yes ]
| join host [ search index=inventory sourcetype=shadow_summary star_accounts>0 dollar_hash_accounts>0 ]
| table host VERSION_ID openssh_pkg_version
```

Assumes RMM scripts collect /etc/os-release, 'sshd -T' output and a count of "*" and $-hash accounts (not the hashes themselves). Adapt to your inventory tooling.

REMEDIATION ACTIONS

Exposure

Product	Affected	Fixed in	CVE	CVSS	EPSS	CISA KEV	KEV due date

Product	Affected	Fixed in	CVE	CVSS	EPSS	CISA KEV	KEV due date
Portable OpenSSH (sshd) on musl libc, PAM disabled	Portable releases through 10.6p1 per the release notes. The bug traces back to a 2016 change; exact affected range not stated by upstream.	10.6p2 (2026-11-05)	None assigned as of 2026-11-06	Not scored (upstream describes it as critical)	N/A (no CVE)	No	N/A
Alpine Linux openssh / openssh-server package	All checked releases: 3.16 through 3.24 and edge	edge 10.6_p2-r0; 3.24 10.3_p1-r2; 3.23 10.2_p1-r1; 3.22 10.0_p1-r11; 3.21 9.9_p2-r1; 3.20 9.7_p1-r6; 3.19 9.6_p1-r3; 3.18 9.3_p2-r4; 3.17 9.1_p1-r7; 3.16 9.0_p1-r6	None assigned	Not scored	N/A	No	N/A
Alpine official tiny-cloud images (AWS AMI, Azure VHD, qcow2)	3.18.11 through 3.24.3 (alpine user with "*" password and passwordless doas)	Images built from 3.21.10, 3.22.8, 3.23.8, 3.24.4 and later; running instances still need the package update	None assigned	Not scored	N/A	No	N/A
Other musl-based builds running OpenSSH without PAM (OpenWrt with OpenSSH installed, Buildroot, Yocto, container images running sshd)	Unknown; depends on vendor build	Vendor-dependent; upstream 10.6p2	None assigned	Not scored	N/A	No	N/A

Immediate (0–24 hours)

- Find every Alpine and other musl-based host, cloud instance, container and appliance that runs sshd. Put internet-facing ones and those built from Alpine tiny-cloud images first. `IT OPS` [S1] [S6]
- Patch Alpine hosts with 'apk upgrade -U -a', then 'rc-service sshd restart'. The package upgrade does not restart the running daemon. `IT OPS` [S2] [S6]

- Where patching must wait, set PasswordAuthentication no in a drop-in such as /etc/ssh/sshd_config.d/00-no-passwords.conf and in every PasswordAuthentication line of /etc/ssh/sshd_config, including Match blocks. Confirm key login first and keep the current session open. Validate with 'sshd -t', restart, and confirm with 'sshd -T | grep -i passwordauthentication'. `IT OPS` [S2] [S6]
- Search /var/log/messages and SIEM data for sshd 'Accepted password for' lines naming accounts with a "*" password field (alpine, root, key-only and directory users). Treat any host where such a login cannot be ruled out as compromised. `SOC` [S1] [S6]

Short term (1–7 days)

- On exposed hosts, review doas usage, recently created users, new or modified files, and authorized_keys changes since the host was deployed. `SOC` [S2] [S6]
- Rebuild cloud instances from fixed images (3.21.10, 3.22.8, 3.23.8, 3.24.4 or later), and update golden images and CI base images that bundle sshd. `IT OPS` [S2] [S6] [S7]
- Ask appliance, firewall, IoT and OT vendors whose products run Buildroot, Yocto or OpenWrt with OpenSSH whether they are affected and when they will ship firmware. `IT OPS` [S1] [S5]
- Move hosts on unsupported Alpine branches (3.21 and older; 3.21 reached end of support on 2026-11-01) onto a supported release plan, even though fixed packages were backported. `LEADERSHIP` [S6]

Long term

- Make key-only or certificate-based SSH the standard and enforce PasswordAuthentication no through configuration management, with drift detection. `IT OPS` [S6]
- Track the C library (musl versus glibc) in the asset inventory so that libc-specific flaws can be scoped quickly. `LEADERSHIP` [S1] [S5]
- Lock unused accounts with '!' rather than '*' where that fits operationally, and remove passwordless doas or sudo rules from default images. `IT OPS` [S2] [S6]
- Watch for CVE assignment and scanner plugin releases, and add them to vulnerability management SLAs once available. `SOC` [S8]

Workarounds & compensating controls

- Restrict SSH to VPN, bastion or allow-listed management networks with security groups and firewalls. Do not expose sshd on musl hosts to the internet. `IT OPS` [S2]
- Where it is supported, run sshd with PAM (openssh-server-pam with UsePAM yes), which the advisory lists as not affected. `IT OPS` [S6]
- Forward Alpine syslog to the SIEM and alert on any password-based SSH login on hosts expected to be key-only. `SOC` [S1] [S6]

Actions marked with an owner: SOC = security operations, IT Ops = system and network administration, Leadership = risk and communications decisions.

SOURCES

[S1] BleepingComputer: OpenSSH flaw lets attackers log into password-disabled Linux accounts
Published 2026-11-05 · `B1` Usually reliable, confirmed by other sources
Press coverage; matches the vendor and distro advisories; gives log hunting commands.

[S2] The Hacker News: OpenSSH issues emergency fix for flaw (musl/Alpine password authentication bypass)
Published 2026-11-05 · `B1` Usually reliable, confirmed by other sources
Press coverage with comment from Damien Miller (OpenSSH) and a detailed summary of the Alpine advisory.

[S3] OpenSSH: OpenSSH Release Notes (10.6p2)
Published 2026-11-05 · `A1` Completely reliable, confirmed by other sources
Primary vendor source; describes a critical security workaround for musl with PAM disabled; no CVE listed.

[S4] oss-security (Damien Miller): Announce: Portable OpenSSH 10.6p2 released
Published 2026-11-05 · `A1` Completely reliable, confirmed by other sources
Primary release announcement; credits Ozgun Kultekin of Wakefield.

[S5] sshhole.com (Ozgun Kultekin): sshole: OpenSSH password bypass on musl libc
Published 2026-11-05 · `B1` Usually reliable, confirmed by other sources
Original researcher write-up with root-cause history and test details; links a public checker. Researcher has no long public track record, but the claims are confirmed by the vendor and Alpine.

[S6] Alpine Linux: Security advisory: openssh-server password authentication bypass
Published 2026-11-05 · `A1` Completely reliable, confirmed by other sources
Primary distro advisory; fixed package versions per branch, exposure conditions, tiny-cloud image range, detection and mitigation steps.

[S7] Alpine Linux: Alpine 3.21.10, 3.22.8, 3.23.8 and 3.24.4 released
Published 2026-11-05 · `A1` Completely reliable, confirmed by other sources
Point releases shipping the openssh-server fix (and an apk-tools crash fix).

[S8] oss-security (Jan Schaumann): "sshole" password authentication bypass (OpenSSH + musl libc)
Published 2026-11-05 · A2 Completely reliable, probably true
Mailing list thread summarizing the issue and fix (MIN_PASSWORD_HASH_LEN check); no CVE mentioned in the thread.

Grades use the Admiralty scale: letter = source reliability (A completely reliable to F cannot be judged), number = information credibility (1 confirmed to 6 cannot be judged).

MISCELLANEOUS

Timeline

Date	Event	Source
2012-08-09	musl changes crypt() to return an unmatchable string ("*") on failure instead of NULL.	[S2] [S5]
2012-08-29	musl adds sha512crypt with a 256-byte key limit, returning "*" for longer inputs.	[S2] [S5]
2016-07-15	OpenSSH salt-borrowing change for CVE-2016-6210 (user enumeration by timing) makes "*" accounts hash attempts with another account's salt.	[S1] [S2] [S5]
2022	Alpine 3.16 (approximately) changes root's shadow field from '!' to '*'.	[S5] [S6]
2026-10-06	OpenSSH 10.6 / 10.6p1 released.	[S3]
2026-11-01	Alpine 3.21 reaches end of support.	[S6]
2026-11-05	OpenSSH 10.6p2 released with the workaround; Alpine advisory and point releases 3.21.10/3.22.8/3.23.8/3.24.4 published; researcher write-up and oss-security disclosure; press coverage.	[S1] [S2] [S3] [S4] [S5] [S6] [S7] [S8]

Relevance to Indianapolis, Indiana & managed clients

Indiana organizations seldom run Alpine as a primary server OS, but musl turns up in less visible places. Examples are Alpine-based containers and cloud VMs used by software teams and SaaS vendors, development and CI hosts, and Alpine instances launched from AWS or Azure marketplace

images. Embedded Linux is another: Buildroot, Yocto and OpenWrt sit inside network gear, IoT and OT gateways in central Indiana manufacturing and logistics, building management systems, and medical device peripherals in hospital networks. Hospitals, local government and school districts often expose vendor-managed appliances over SSH for remote support, and they may not control the firmware schedule. For managed IT service clients, the practical work is to sweep RMM and cloud inventories for Alpine and musl hosts that accept SSH passwords, push the apk upgrade and sshd restart, or enforce PasswordAuthentication no, and to ask appliance vendors for statements. Small and mid-size businesses running Alpine-based VPN, monitoring or self-hosted tools on public cloud with SSH open to the internet face the highest risk. No Indiana-specific targeting has been reported.

Intelligence gaps

- No CVE, CVSS score, EPSS score or KEV status yet. Watch for CVE assignment and NVD scoring.
- Upstream has not stated the exact range of affected OpenSSH versions beyond the change history back to 2016.
- Which commercial appliances and embedded products ship OpenSSH on musl without PAM is unknown. Vendor advisories are still to come.
- Unknown whether musl will change crypt() failure behavior. Other software that compares crypt() output against stored fields without PAM may have similar flaws.
- No telemetry yet on scanning or exploitation attempts. Watch honeypot and threat-intel reporting (SANS ISC, GreyNoise and others) for long-password SSH attempts.
- Coverage for non-Alpine musl distributions (for example Void musl, postmarketOS, Chimera) was not confirmed in the sources reviewed.

Other notes

- OpenSSH describes the fix as a 'critical security workaround'. The briefing rates the item High, reflecting the narrow set of preconditions. Defenders running exposed Alpine hosts should treat it as critical.
- OpenSSH says the root cause lies in musl's crypt() behavior rather than sshd. The 10.6p2 workaround refuses a match when the stored hash field is shorter than four characters (MIN_PASSWORD_HASH_LEN).
- OpenWrt uses Dropbear by default, which the researcher says is not affected. Only OpenWrt builds with OpenSSH server installed are in scope.
- Alpine images that use cloud-init write PasswordAuthentication no and are not affected by default. The tiny-cloud images are the concern.
- The researcher reportedly used AI agents to run roughly 17,600 authentication test cases. The OpenSSH team says it plans more frequent releases partly because AI-found bugs are being rediscovered independently.
- The 10.6p2 release also added the hybrid ssh-mldsa44-ed25519 CA signature algorithm and an scp -R deprecation warning. These are unrelated to the security issue.

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Back to the daily briefing.

TLP:CLEAR Unrestricted public release.